their contacts with the leaders of the Soviet Union. With Soviet missiles on Cuba, the Chinese were convinced that the USA would be too preoccupied to pay much attention to a war in the distant Himalayas.[14]

Given the increasingly hostile relations between China and the Soviet Union at the time, the Soviet leader Nikita Khrushchev did not himself tell Mao that he was sending missiles to Cuba, and, as Riedel, writes in his book: 'Nor did Mao tell Moscow that he was going to war with India until two days before the attack.'[15] However, according to British analyst and writer Roderick MacFarquhar, China's Moscow ambassador, Liu Xiao, reportedly 'informed Beijing in advance about Khrushchev's missile plan although the Chinese probably knew about it anyway, for they had excellent sources of information in Cuba'.[16]

Chinese intelligence gathering in the NEFA may even have begun well before 1959, the year Deng Xiaoping said that 'accounts' would have to be 'settled' with India. According to a 1952 intelligence report, it had then just been detected that Tibetan monks from a dissident sect, not loyal to the Dalai Lama, had been sent into India 'as spies and agitators'. The same sect had, the report also stated, 'acted as their [the Chinese] fifth-column during the [1950] occupation of Tibet'.[17]

It is also clear that China was prepared for a long conflict with India. But after 1962, it would be a proxy war, fought by rebel forces inside India. The seemingly unlikely partner would be the Nagas, a predominantly Christian tribe living in the hills of the easternmost part of India. Led by Angami Zapu Phizo, they had declared their independence on 14 August 1947, a day ahead of India, and had taken up arms against the government in New Delhi. Almost immediately, they received military support from India's arch-rival, Pakistan. Naga rebels were also permitted to set up camps in the eastern part of Pakistan, now Bangladesh, from where they launched raids into India. Phizo himself had continued from East Pakistan via Switzerland to Britain, where, from his exile in Kent, he stayed in touch with his comrades in the Naga Hills.

In June 1962, one of the Naga rebel commanders, Mowu Gwizan, stopped over in Karachi on his way to London to see Phizo. While in Karachi, Mowu's Pakistani hosts introduced him to a 'Chinese friend', who promised the Nagas aid and assistance.[18] As a result of that meeting, the Nagas assembled a force of 132 men who eventually set off from the Naga